

Dogs and laws: On street dogs and the Supreme Court order

Urban local bodies need funding for shelters and **sterilisation drives**

The August 11, 2025 Supreme Court order represents the most forceful judicial **intervention** yet on the matter of free-roaming dogs. By **directing** Delhi and its satellites to collect every street dog within eight weeks, **confine** them permanently in **pounds**, and **expand** shelter capacity at speed, the Court has **signalled** its **willingness** to **override** administrative **lethargy**. Delhi records roughly 30,000 dog bite cases a year and **rabies** still kills poor urban residents with **patchy** access to **post-exposure prophylaxis**. The Court's **blunt** instrument conflicts with the Animal Birth Control Rules 2023, specifically its **doctrine** of "capture, **neuter**, vaccinate, release", and which **forbid** municipalities from permanently **relocating** healthy dogs or impounding them for long periods except if a dog is **rabid**, **incurably** ill or found to be dangerously aggressive by a **veterinarian**. The Rules have failed the test of numbers, however. Urban dog populations have continued to **swell** despite **sporadic** sterilisation drives because **70% coverage**, below which reproduction **rebounds**, **has** almost **nowhere** been reached. The **prescription** to return dogs to their territories **has entrenched packs** in the same high-density **neighbourhoods** where children play and garbage **accumulates**. The Rules also block municipalities from exploring alternative strategies such as long-term **impoundment**. Now, if the Rules are **intact**, municipal officers who **confine** dogs could be **prosecuted**; if they **obey** the Rules, they risk **contempt** of court.

Policymakers should treat this conflict as an opportunity to **confront** an **outdated** legal setup. The **Prevention** of Cruelty to Animals Act 1960 **was enacted** when India's urban **footprint** was **modest**. Today's **conurbations** with **dense informal settlements** **cannot** afford such dog populations. **Entrenched ideological** positions that **romanticise** "community dogs" and **regard confinement** as **oppression** **take** insufficient **account of** the dense human **ecology**. A modern **statute** should clearly **distinguish** between **sociable** dogs that can find homes; aggressive or **chronically** ill dogs that require **euthanasia**; and the large **residual** category that can live in proper shelters — but none on public roads. Cities should **impose** duties on municipalities, specify minimum staffing and veterinary standards for pounds, and tie **fiscal** transfers to reductions in **morbidity**. Urban local bodies also need **steady** funding, **perhaps** under the National Centre for Disease Control, to **bankroll** the construction and operation of shelters and to fund **large-scale** sterilisation teams. Veterinary education councils should **integrate** shelter medicine into **curricula** to ensure a workforce **exists** to **staff** new facilities. Without such support, Delhi risks **swapping** its dog **menace** with underfunded **canine slammers** at the city's **edge**, invisible but also **cruel**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Staff** (verb) - provide (an organization, business, etc.) with staff.

Vocabulary

1. **Sterilisation** (noun) – castration, neutering, spaying, birth control, desexing नसबंदी
2. **Drive** (noun) – campaign, effort, push, initiative, operation अभियान
3. **Intervention** (noun) – involvement, interference, mediation, action, intrusion हस्तक्षेप
4. **Direct** (verb) – instruct, order, command, guide, tell निर्देश देना
5. **Confine** (verb) – restrict, imprison, enclose, detain, limit कैद करना
6. **Pound** (noun) – animal shelter, kennel, cage, enclosure, compound पशु आश्रय
7. **Expand** (verb) – increase, enlarge, broaden, extend, grow विस्तार करना
8. **Signal** (verb) – indicate, show, convey, announce, demonstrate संकेत देना
9. **Willingness** (noun) – readiness, inclination, preparedness, eagerness, consent इच्छा
10. **Override** (verb) – overrule, annul, supersede, cancel, invalidate अमान्य करना
11. **Lethargy** (noun) – laziness, sluggishness, inactivity, apathy, indolence सुस्ती / आलस्य
12. **Rabies** (noun) – a deadly virus spread to people from the saliva of infected animals रेबीज
13. **Patchy** (adjective) – uneven, inconsistent, irregular, sporadic, variable असमान / अधूरा
14. **Post-exposure** (noun) – after contact, following exposure संपर्क के बाद का
15. **Prophylaxis** (noun) – prevention, precaution, protective treatment रोग-निवारण
16. **Blunt** (adjective) – straightforward, direct, plain-spoken, brusque, abrupt स्पष्टवादी / सीधा
17. **Doctrine** (noun) – principle, belief, tenet, theory, policy सिद्धांत / मत
18. **Neuter** (verb) – castrate, sterilise, spay, fix, desex नसबंदी करना
19. **Forbid** (verb) – prohibit, ban, bar, disallow, prevent रोकना
20. **Relocate** (verb) – move, transfer, shift, resettle, reposition स्थानांतरित करना
21. **Rabid** (adjective) – infected with rabies, furious, extreme, fanatical रेबीजग्रस्त
22. **Incurably** (adverb) – hopelessly, irreversibly, permanently असाध्य रूप से
23. **Veterinarian** (adjective) – relating to animal medicine, veterinary पशु चिकित्सक-संबंधी
24. **Swell** (verb) – increase, grow, expand, enlarge, inflate बढ़ना / फैलना

25. **Sporadic** (adjective) – occasional, irregular, infrequent, scattered, patchy कभी-कभी होने वाला
26. **Rebound** (noun) – recovery, bounce-back, resurgence, return फिर से उठना
27. **Nowhere** (adverb) – not anywhere, in no place, absent कहीं नहीं
28. **Entrench** (verb) – establish firmly, embed, secure, fortify मज़बूत करना / जमाना
29. **Pack** (noun) – group, gang, troop, cluster, herd झुंड
30. **Neighbourhood** (noun) – locality, area, community, vicinity, district पड़ोस / मोहल्ला
31. **Accumulate** (verb) – gather, collect, amass, pile up, store इकट्ठा करना
32. **Impoundment** (noun) – confinement, seizure, detention, custody कैद / जब्ती
33. **Intact** (adjective) – undamaged, whole, complete, unharmed अक्षुण्ण / सलामत
34. **Prosecute** (verb) – charge, try, indict, sue, pursue legally मुकदमा चलाना
35. **Obey** (verb) – follow, comply, heed, conform, submit आज्ञा मानना
36. **Contempt** (noun) – disrespect, disregard, scorn, disdain, disobedience अवमानना
37. **Confront** (verb) – face, challenge, tackle, meet, oppose सामना करना
38. **Outdated** (adjective) – old-fashioned, obsolete, archaic, outmoded पुराना / अप्रचलित
39. **Enact** (verb) – pass, legislate, approve, decree, establish कानून बनाना
40. **Footprint** (noun) – mark, impression, impact, presence पदचिह्न / प्रभाव
41. **Modest** (adjective) – small, limited, moderate, humble, unpretentious छोटा / साधारण
42. **Conurbation** (noun) – urban area, city region, metropolitan zone शहरी क्षेत्र
43. **Dense** (adjective) – thick, crowded, packed, compact घना / सघन
44. **Informal settlement** (noun) – slum, shanty town, unplanned housing अनौपचारिक बस्ती
45. **Entrenched** (adjective) – established, ingrained, fixed, deep-rooted मज़बूत / जड़ जमा हुआ
46. **Ideological** (adjective) – doctrinal, philosophical, theoretical, belief-based वैचारिक
47. **Romanticise** (verb) – idealise, glorify, sentimentalise, overpraise आदर्श बनाना / भावुक बनाना

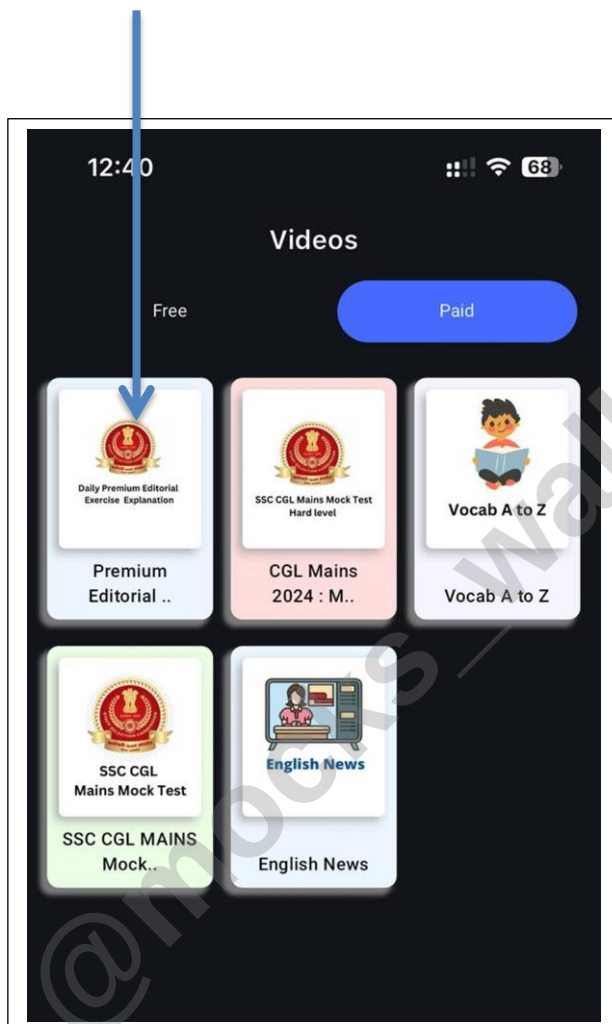
48. **Regard** (as) (verb) – consider, view, deem, see, treat मानना / समझना
49. **Confinement** (noun) – imprisonment, restriction, detention, custody कैद / बंधन
50. **Oppression** (noun) – persecution, tyranny, injustice, cruelty दमन / अत्याचार
51. **Take account of** (phrase) – consider, include, factor in, keep in mind ध्यान में रखना
52. **Ecology** (noun) – environment, biosphere, ecosystem, surroundings पारिस्थितिकी
53. **Statute** (noun) – law, act, regulation, ordinance, legislation कानून / अधिनियम
54. **Distinguish** (verb) – differentiate, discern, recognise, tell apart अंतर करना / पहचानना
55. **Sociable** (adjective) – friendly, outgoing, companionable, genial मिलनसार
56. **Chronically** (adverb) – persistently, constantly, continuously, repeatedly दीर्घकालिक रूप से
57. **Euthanasia** (noun) – mercy killing, assisted death, putting down दया मृत्यु / इच्छामृत्यु
58. **Residual** (adjective) – remaining, leftover, surplus, extra शेष / बचा हुआ
59. **Impose** (verb) – enforce, levy, dictate, command थोपना / लागू करना
60. **Fiscal** (adjective) – financial, monetary, economic, budgetary वित्तीय
61. **Morbidity** (noun) – illness, disease, sickness rate, infirmity रुग्णता
62. **Steady** (adjective) – stable, constant, reliable, regular स्थिर / लगातार
63. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, potentially शायद
64. **Bankroll** (verb) – finance, fund, sponsor, support वित्तपोषण करना
65. **Large-scale** (adjective) – extensive, massive, widespread, big बड़े पैमाने पर
66. **Integrate** (verb) – combine, merge, incorporate, unify एकीकृत करना
67. **Curricula** (noun) – syllabi, course content, study programmes पाठ्यक्रम
68. **Exist** (verb) – live, survive, be, occur, subsist मौजूद होना / रहना
69. **Swap** (verb) – exchange, trade, switch, change बदलना / अदला-बदली करना
70. **Menace** (noun) – threat, danger, nuisance, hazard खतरा / उपद्रव
71. **Canine** (adjective) – relating to dogs, dog-like कुत्तों से संबंधित
72. **Slammer** (noun) – jail, prison, lock-up, detention facility जेल / कैदखाना

73. **Edge** (noun) – border, boundary, margin,
limit किनारा / सीमा

74. **Cruel** (adjective) – brutal, inhumane,
ruthless, merciless क्रूर / निर्दयी

@mocks_wallah

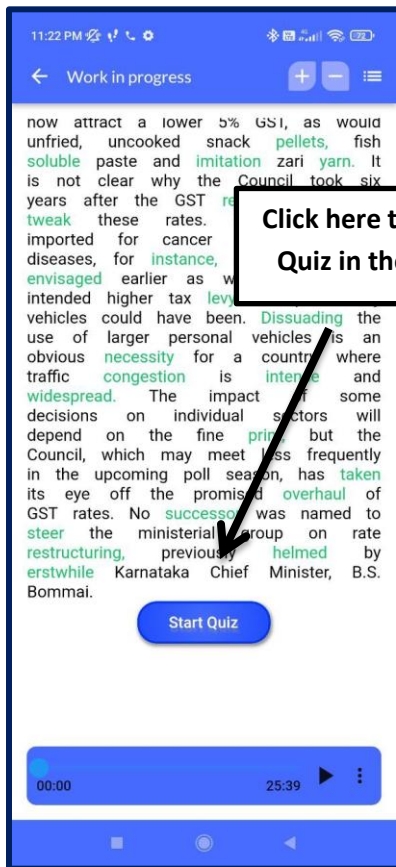
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Summary of the Editorial

1. **Supreme Court Order (Aug 11, 2025)** – The Court ordered Delhi and nearby cities to collect all street dogs within eight weeks, confine them permanently in pounds, and expand shelter capacity rapidly.
2. **Reason for Intervention** – Delhi records around 30,000 dog bite cases annually, and rabies continues to kill poor urban residents lacking proper access to post-exposure treatment.
3. **Conflict with Animal Birth Control Rules 2023** – These rules follow the “capture, neuter, vaccinate, release” method and forbid permanent relocation or long-term impoundment of healthy dogs, except in special cases.
4. **Limited Success of Current Rules** – Dog populations keep increasing because sterilisation coverage rarely reaches the 70% threshold needed to curb reproduction.
5. **Impact of Release Policy** – Returning dogs to their original areas has reinforced packs in crowded neighbourhoods where children play and garbage accumulates.
6. **Restrictions on Municipalities** – Rules prevent cities from using long-term impoundment or alternative strategies to control dog numbers.
7. **Legal Dilemma for Officials** – Following the Court’s order may lead to prosecution under existing rules, while following the rules risks contempt of court.
8. **Need for Legal Reform** – The Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act 1960 is outdated and does not reflect today’s dense urban realities.
9. **Ideological Divide** – Some groups romanticise “community dogs” and see confinement as oppression, ignoring the risks in high-density human environments.
10. **Proposed Modern Approach** – Classify dogs into three categories:
 - Sociable dogs suitable for adoption.
 - Aggressive or chronically ill dogs requiring euthanasia.
 - The rest to be housed in proper shelters, not on public roads.
11. **Municipal Responsibility** – Cities should be legally bound to maintain minimum staffing, veterinary care standards, and proper pound facilities.
12. **Link Funding to Results** – Fiscal transfers to cities should be tied to reductions in dog-bite cases and rabies morbidity.
13. **Central Funding Role** – The National Centre for Disease Control could finance shelters and large-scale sterilisation drives.
14. **Veterinary Training Reform** – Shelter medicine should be included in veterinary education to create a skilled workforce for new facilities.
15. **Risk of Poor Implementation** – Without adequate funding and planning, Delhi might replace street dog problems with poorly run, overcrowded shelters that are equally inhumane.

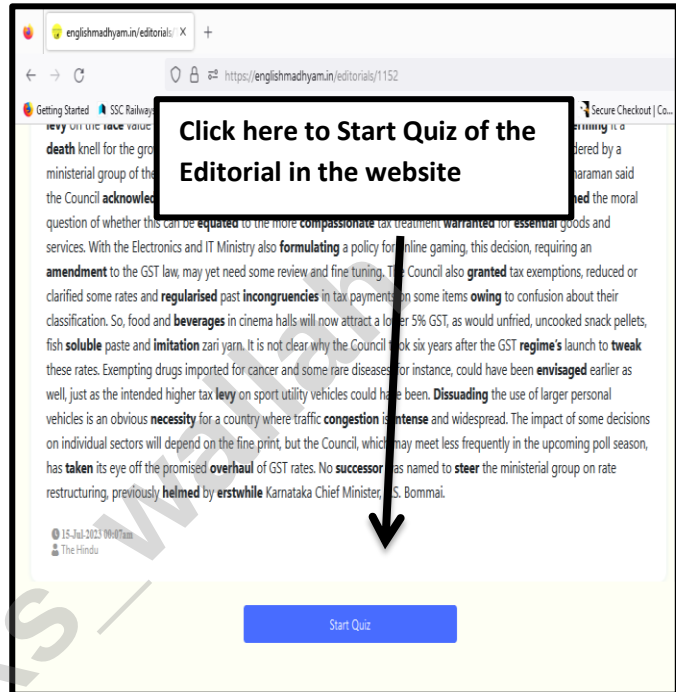
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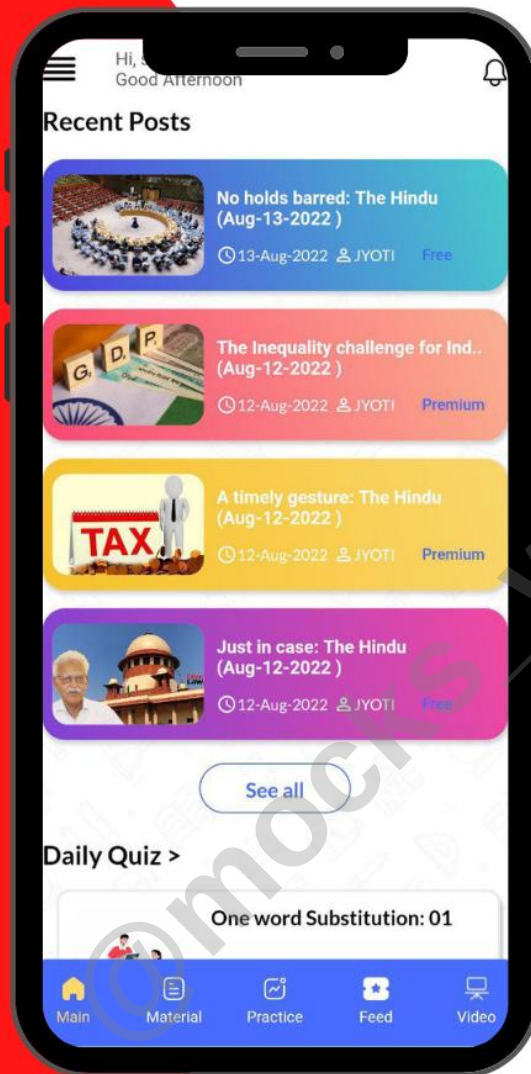
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